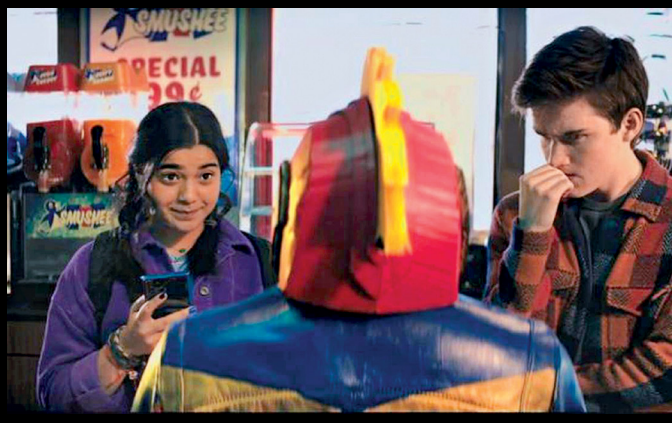
CINEMA

NEW KHAN IN TOWN

***Ms Marvel**'s South Asian protagonist Kamala Khan is a hero and a healer*







On June 8, the day the first episode of *Ms Marvel* dropped on Disney+ Hotstar, Marvel Studios posted on Instagram a note Malala Yousafzai had written by hand: "It is not every day that I turn on the TV and find a character who eats the same foods, listens to the same music or uses the same Urdu phrases as me. What a joy to see Ms Marvel reflect the lives of a Pakistani immigrant family and reveal a young superhero whose powers connect to her heritage. Thank you, Marvel and Disney+, and most importantly, Ms Marvel." Yousafzai does, of course, know a thing or two about heroism, but to see the Nobel laureate be so obvious a fangirl seemed odd. Marvel must have done something very right.

While Yousafzai seemed to relish the representation of 'people like us', South Asians on social media were celebrating *Ms Marvel*'s somewhat bold suggestion: we don't have to walk a whole extra mile for people to like us. The show's depiction of a Pakistani American family felt authentic, and there was little apology in its representation of race or religion. Kamala Khan (Iman Vellani) says *bismillah* before starting (and failing) her driving test. Her father quotes from the Quran, "If you save one life, you save the world," and, then, legs dangling from a rooftop, the 16-year-old protagonist tells her best friend, "It's not the Brown girls from Jersey City who save the world." Everything here comes full circle.

> Ms Marvel's Pakistani American family feels authentic and the show is unapologetic about its representation of race or religion

Superhero origin stories are always stories of becoming. In *Ms Marvel*, we see Kamala transformed by a family heirloom, a bangle her grandmother has sent from Pakistan. Though it gives her powers she believes only her beloved Marvel heroes have, it also seems to carry the inheritance of Parti-